

Kenneth Watts

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Education

University of Virginia, Incoming PhD in Statistics August 2026 – May 2030

Research interests: Applied Probability, Dependence Modeling, Sports Analytics and non-normality

University of Pennsylvania, Bachelor of Science in Economics August 2022 – May 2026

Concentrations: Statistics and Quantitative Finance

Takapuna Grammar School, New Zealand January 2020 – November 2021

Dux (Valedictorian Equivalent)

Publication(s)

Kicking for goal or touch? An expected points framework for penalty decisions in rugby union September 2026

Journal of Quantitative Analysis in Sports (JQAS)

<https://www.degruyterbrill.com/document/doi/10.1515/jqas-2025-0183/html>

The first expected points paper in the sport of rugby union, optimizing the penalty decision.

Papers

Dummy RAPM August 2026

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2608.19454>

We introduce Dummy RAPM, an incremental improvement to RAPM which explicitly includes the count of excluded low-minute players on the court for each team as an additional regressor.

A Dynamic Rating System for NFL Pass Rushers and Blockers August 2025

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2604.01491>

A framework for rating NFL offensive and defensive linemen using player tracking data and individual play interactions.

Selected for a poster presentation at the New England Symposium on Statistics in Sports (NESSIS) at Harvard University

Work Experience

Injury modeling for the Cleveland Browns December 2025 – Present

Streamlining data feeds relating to player injuries to calculate, and then predict, games missed due to injuries.

Creating NFL player comparisons, in terms of injury profile, for pre-draft college football players. Selected as one of 6 undergraduate/graduate students from the Wharton Sports Analytics and Business Initiative to complete this project.

Moneyball Academy, University of Pennsylvania, Wharton June 2025 – August 2025

Teaching Assistant

Teaching assistant for Professor Wyner's Moneyball Academy, teaching students about statistics through sports examples using the R programming language

First Cape, Global Equities, Auckland

May 2024 – August 2024

Equity Research Analyst

Sole analyst under the Global Equities Portfolio Manager for a \$1.5bn portfolio.

Led meetings with sell-side analysts and investor relations.

Built valuations models for 25 portfolio companies and updated a quantitative screening tool for stock selection.

Jarden, Wealth Research, Auckland

June 2023 – August 2023

Equity Research Analyst

Built an interactive client-portfolio dashboard using Power BI

Cleaned and analyzed large Excel data sets to assist with portfolio diversification and optimization

Poster Presentations*A Dynamic Rating System for NFL Pass Rushers and Blockers*

New England Symposium on Statistics in Sports (NESSIS), Boston

September 2025

Wharton Sports Business Summit, Philadelphia

September 2025

Awards & Achievements

United States National Collegiate Rugby All Star

2024/25

University of Pennsylvania Rugby Captain

2023/24 and 2024/25

New Zealand Top Scholars Award – Takapuna Grammar School

2021

Dux (Valedictorian Equivalent) – Takapuna Grammar School

2021

Miscellaneous

Reading: Have read 35–40 books per year since 2021

Some favorites include: Fooled By Randomness, The Billion Dollar Molecule, Barbarians at the Gate, Catch-22, When Genius Failed, and the Jason Bourne Books.

Running: Sub 17 minute 5k; run 3–4x per week.
